ENS DAO Stakeholder Analysis & Retro

Executive Summary

This research proposes a rigorous mixed-methods study to diagnose governance and operational challenges within the ENS DAO and to generate a prioritized, evidence-based roadmap for institutional and coordination improvements.

The work combines structured stakeholder analysis, systematic review of documents and data, comparative DAO research, and a retrospective assessment of past spending to produce both a clear diagnosis and actionable recommendations for the ENS DAO.

The study has three primary goals.

- First, at the institutional level, it will provide ENS DAO with concrete options for proactive, evidence-grounded governance and organizational design reforms.
- Second, at the community level, it will offer transparent, credible analysis of current challenges and solution paths, helping build shared understanding and legitimacy around any proposed changes.
- Third, at the ecosystem level, it will generate transferable lessons for DAO governance practitioners and researchers working on similar public-goods infrastructures.

The research is organized into four phases:

- Phase 1: Stakeholder analysis and pre-retro data collection
- Phase 2: Comparative DAO research
- Phase 3: Retrospective assessment of spend
- Phase 4: Synthesis and presentation

Throughout the process, milestone check-ins ensure that ENS stakeholders can review interim findings, confirm alignment on research questions and methods, and provide feedback that is incorporated before moving to subsequent phases.

The final outputs will include a full research report, concise forum posts and presentation materials for the ENS community, and a governance roadmap that links specific problems to proposed reforms, their evidence base, and practical next steps for ENS DAO.

Introduction and Overview

Research Context and Problem Statement

The Ethereum Name Service (ENS) has emerged as foundational public-goods infrastructure for web3, providing decentralized naming and identity services across the Ethereum ecosystem. Following the November 2021 governance token launch, ENS transitioned to a decentralized autonomous organization (DAO) model, establishing a tiered governance system comprising token holders, delegates, working-group stewards, and a Security Council.

Despite robust constitutional design and formal governance architecture, ENS DAO has experienced challenges in governance effectiveness and stakeholder coordination based on observational data from discussion forums, individual conversations, etc.

Reported Challenge	**Impact**
Voting power concentration	Concentrated decision-making; representativeness concerns
Low broad-based participation in governance	Governance legitimacy questioned; passive token holders
Communication fragmentation across stakeholder groups	Misaligned expectations; duplicated effort; slow execution
De facto centralization of real decision-making	Process friction; innovation bottleneck; contributor burn-out
Treasury and institutional liability risk	Legal and governance sustainability uncertainty

These reported challenges will serve as the initial focus for developing research questions and will inform the overall research design. The challenges, the research questions they generate, and the overall research objectives will be validated, refined, and expanded as evidence emerges throughout the process.

This research will provide:

1. **Systematic stakeholder evidence**: Rigorous documentation of governance challenges from the perspective of each stakeholder tier (stewards, delegates, token holders, service providers, researchers).
2. **Root-cause analysis**: Moving beyond symptom description to understanding structural, cultural, and incentive drivers of observed challenges in a retrospective analysis.

3. **Comparative learning**: Evidence-graded inventory of governance reforms attempted in comparable DAOs (e.g., Uniswap, Arbitrum, Optimism, Aave, Lido) with documented outcomes.

4. **Actionable roadmap**: Prioritized, phased recommendations with clear implementation pathways and success criteria.

Research Goals

This research serves three complementary goals:

- **Institutional**: Provide ENS DAO with recommendations for any desired proactive, evidence-based institutional design.
- **Community**: Provide all stakeholder groups with transparent, credible diagnosis and solution options, increasing consensus and legitimacy around governance reforms.
- **Ecosystem**: Generate lessons and transferable insights relevant to maturing DAO governance practitioners and researchers.

Research Questions

The research is organized around two primary research questions and five supporting sub-questions (all research questions will be validated, modified and added to as evidence emerges through the course of the research):

Primary Research Questions

RQ1: What are the root causes of communication and operational inefficiency within ENS DAO governance, and how are these causes perceived and prioritized differently across stakeholder groups (stewards, delegates, token holders, service providers)?

- This question moves beyond acknowledgment of problems to systematic diagnosis of underlying drivers, acknowledging that different stakeholders may identify distinct root causes based on their positional perspectives.

RQ2: What changes—informed by comparative DAO research, organizational theory, and stakeholder input—are most likely to improve ENS DAO coordination and execution effectiveness while maintaining commitment to decentralization and broad stakeholder inclusion?

- This question translates diagnostic insights into design solutions, grounded in both external evidence and stakeholder acceptability.

Supporting Research Sub-Questions

RQ1a: How does each stakeholder group (stewards, delegates, token holders, service providers, MetaGov advisors, core contributors) perceive ENS DAO's governance performance across communication clarity, decision-speed, transparency, representativeness, and accountability, amongst others?

RQ1b: What documented evidence exists (via forum records, governance timelines, treasury data, and participant accounts) of information asymmetries, bottlenecks, or delays between governance tiers (token holders → delegates → stewards → working groups → execution)?

RQ2a: How have comparable DAOs (e.g., Uniswap, Arbitrum, Optimism, Aave, Lido, and emerging experimental models) diagnosed and implemented solutions to similar coordination and representativeness challenges, and what quantitative or qualitative evidence of success exists?

RQ2b: Which innovations (e.g., improved delegation mechanisms, federated steward structures, process automation, standing committees, incentive realignment) simultaneously improve both governance speed and decentralization in comparable contexts?

RQ2c: What institutional, cultural, and technical prerequisites exist for the successful implementation of candidate reforms within ENS DAO's specific context (tokenomics, stakeholder composition, existing infrastructure, regulatory environment)?

Methodology and Process

Study Design Overview

This design is a mixed-methods case study with embedded comparative elements and relies on systematic qualitative inquiry, document analysis, and structured comparative method to build robust causal understanding of governance dysfunction.

There are four phases to the research with milestones built in to provide the opportunity for ENS stakeholders to ensure the research fulfills their objectives, adheres to the research design and provide feedback on emergent findings and provide input on remaining research tasks.

1. **Stakeholder analysis and pre-retro data collection**: Phase 1 focuses on building a shared, evidence-based understanding of ENS DAO's current governance reality across key stakeholder groups and on preparing the data foundation required for a rigorous retrospective. This phase combines structured stakeholder analysis with targeted pre-retro data collection, so that the eventual assessment of "what worked and what did not" is anchored in the DAO's stated purposes, desired outcomes, and actual operational history.
2. **Comparative Assessment**: Phase 2 situates ENS DAO's challenges and opportunities within the broader landscape of DAO governance practice through comparative research and evidence synthesis across 4–6 carefully selected decentralized communities. By documenting how other ecosystems have diagnosed similar problems, what reforms they attempted, and what evidence exists of those reforms' effectiveness. This phase will generate a menu of externally validated solution models that can later be assessed for fit with ENS DAO's specific context.

3. **Retrospective**: Phase 3 conducts a structured retrospective on ENS DAO spending and governance performance, using the purpose statements and desired outcomes articulated in Phase 1 alongside the data assembled through pre-retro collection. The goal is to determine the extent to which key initiatives, programs, and governance processes delivered on their intended outcomes, and to surface root-cause patterns that connect specific results (or failures) to underlying institutional design and implementation choices.
4. **Final Reporting**: Phase 4 synthesizes insights from stakeholder analysis, comparative research, and the retrospective into a coherent diagnosis and an actionable package of recommendations for ENS DAO. This includes a full research report and community-facing materials, designed to support transparent deliberation, consensus-building, and staged implementation of governance and organizational reforms aligned with ENS DAO's long-term mission.

Phase 1 - Stakeholder Analysis and Pre-Retro Data Gathering

Overview

Phase 1 establishes the analytic and relational foundation for the entire study by clarifying ENS DAO's purpose, mapping its stakeholder ecosystem, and documenting how different groups currently experience governance, coordination, and execution. Through background research, structured interviews, community discussions, and targeted external scanning, this phase generates a shared, multi-perspective picture of "how ENS DAO is working today" and what outcomes its stakeholders believe recent spending and governance decisions were meant to achieve.

Phase 1A. Stakeholder Analysis

Goal

To have a clear understanding of

- What is the purpose of the DAO?
- What are the problems the DAO is facing?
- What were the desired outcomes of your spend that we will be reviewing in Phase 3?

Activities

1. Background context and ENS DAO research
    a. Thoroughly reviewing the forum, community calls, and any other relevant materials, including initial conversations with the MetaGov team
    b. Map the relevant stakeholders of ENS DAO (i.e., Delegates, Tokenholders, Stewards, Service Providers, Labs, etc.)
        i. Role and formal authority (voting rights, execution rights, advisory)
        ii. Interests and known incentives
        iii. Reported engagement patterns and participation constraints
        iv. Known areas of alignment and conflict
    c. Starting to sketch some potential areas for improvement

2. Conduct stakeholder interviews
    a. Conducting 25+ hours of interviews with key stakeholders
    b. Creating a process for anonymous and/or asynchronous contribution to the stakeholder analysis portion for those who are not able or interested in being interviewed
    c. Potentially hosting up to 5 hours worth of community discussions to better understand the nature of the challenges from the perspective of both delegates and the broader community
    d. Producing an overview of the perceived challenges from the perspective of key stakeholders relating to how ENS DAO can improve
3. External research and continued community observation
    a. Conducting reviews of other DAOs and decentralized communities for a better understanding of how they dealt with similar challenges
    b. Producing a set of recommendations based on external research and stakeholder interviews
4. Present findings and recommendations to the MetaGov team and the community
    a. Producing at least one forum post outlining the results of the research and findings
    b. Partaking in 1-2 community calls to discuss conclusions and receive feedback
    c. Hosting at least 1-2 dedicated calls with the MetaGov team to receive feedback on the recommendations
    d. Producing a revised list of recommendations that factor in both the research findings and the community's and MetaGov's reception of said findings

Outputs:

1. Summary of the current state of affairs in terms of ENS DAO (Activity 1 above) and a list of whom to interview
2. Outlining the research questions that are at the core of the retro (see initial draft of research questions above)

Phase 1B. Pre-Retro Data Collection

Goal:

- To gather all of the relevant data that needs to be analyzed to understand if the desired outcomes defined through Phase 1 were or were not accomplished as part of conducting the full retro in Phase 2
- To prepare funding data for ingestion, indexing, and aggregation within the OpenGrants data stack

Activities:

- Design and implement a structured data inventory process (templates and checklists) to identify all initiatives, grants, working-group programs, and major governance decisions that will be included in the retrospective.

- Produce a master catalog of relevant documents and data sources (forum threads, proposals, working-group reports, treasury and disbursement data, ENS Labs updates, call notes, dashboards, and any off-chain documentation).
- Create and maintain a shared data repository for unstructured documents (e.g., forum exports, meeting notes, slide decks, research reports) with clear naming conventions and access controls.
- Outline and document standard operating procedures for sharing relevant data with the research team, including who is responsible for providing which data, in what format, and on what timeline.
- Where needed, work with stewards, service providers, and ENS Labs to generate structured exports of key quantitative data (e.g., transaction histories, budget vs. actuals, participation metrics) for inclusion in the repository.
- Log initial data quality issues and gaps (e.g., missing reports, inconsistent categorization, incomplete forum documentation) to inform both the design of the retrospective in Phase 3 and any recommendations about future data practice

Outputs:

- A data repository that will be used for the actual retrospective analysis

Milestone 1

Upon completion of Phase 1, the research team will produce a Phase 1 Stakeholder Analysis and Pre-Retro Data Collection package, including: (a) a concise summary of ENS DAO's purpose, problem statements, and desired outcomes as articulated by key stakeholder groups; (b) a stakeholder map with roles, authorities, incentives, and observed engagement patterns; and (c) a documented inventory and structure for the pre-retro data repository. This package will be submitted to the designated ENS stakeholder group (e.g., MetaGov team, stewards, and selected delegates) for review.

Within one week of submission, the research team and ENS stakeholders will hold a milestone check-in call to: (1) validate or refine the emerging picture of ENS DAO's purpose, challenges, and intended outcomes; (2) confirm that the planned research methods and data sources for subsequent phases are appropriate and aligned with ENS priorities; and (3) surface any gaps, concerns, or additional questions. Following this session, the research team will revise the Phase 1 outputs and, where needed, adjust research questions, methods, or sampling plans to incorporate ENS feedback before formally closing the Phase 1 milestone.

Phase 2 - Comparative DAO research post stakeholder analysis

Goal

- Understand how other DAOs or decentralized ecosystems have dealt with similar problems

Activities:

- Comparative DAO research and evidence synthesis to ground findings in comparative DAO governance literature; identify solution models with documented evidence of effectiveness; synthesize external evidence with stakeholder input.

For each case, we will systematically document:

- Governance problem identified and timeline of its emergence
- Reform(s) attempted and mechanism of institutional change (who decided? how implemented?)
- Available evidence of effectiveness (quantitative: voting participation rates, proposal speed, delegate diversity; qualitative: stakeholder perception, sustainability)
- Transferability assessment: What context-specific factors enabled or hindered the reform? How do they map to ENS DAO conditions?

It is important to note that this comparison research will not involve any primary data collection through interviews or focus groups, surveys, etc. and will be entirely done through secondary data collection of forum discussion, blogs and other grey literature, etc.

Outputs

A structured comparative evidence base that directly links ENS DAO's observed challenges to specific reform patterns in other DAOs. For each selected case the output will include:

- a concise case profile and a timeline of the governance problem and reforms
- documented evidence of effectiveness, and an assessment of how transferable each reform is to ENS DAO's context.

These will be synthesized into an evidence-graded catalogue of candidate governance and organizational interventions, explicitly mapped to the issues surfaced in Phase 1 and ready to be assessed during the retrospective and final recommendation phases.

Phase 3 - Retrospective Assessment

Goal

Analyse the data capture in Phase 1 in light of the purpose and desired outcomes articulated in Phase 1 & the Milestone 1 review to assess whether or not the spend was accomplishing what was intended.

Activities

Phase 3 will systematically analyze the initiatives, grants, and governance processes identified in Phase 1 using the data assembled in the pre-retro repository. Activities will include:

- Reconstructing the intended theory of change and desired outcomes for major spending streams
- coding qualitative and quantitative evidence against those intended outcomes
- identifying cross-cutting patterns of success, failure, and unintended consequences.

The team will convene at least one milestone review (see below) with ENS Stakeholders and relevant stewards to validate interpretations, refine emerging findings, and prioritize issues that require deeper investigation before final synthesis

Outputs
The research team will generate a structured retrospective assessment that clearly links ENS DAO's historical spending and governance decisions to their observed outcomes. Outputs will include:

- a set of initiative-level and thematic retro summaries
- An integrated analysis of root causes behind recurrent challenges
- a prioritized list of leverage points where institutional or procedural changes are most likely to improve coordination and execution.

These outputs will feed directly into Phase 4, providing the empirical backbone for the final recommendations and governance roadmap.

Milestone 2

Upon completion of Phase 2, the research team will produce a Comparative DAO Research overview, including: (a) short case profiles for each selected DAO; (b) a summary of governance problems, reforms, and available evidence of effectiveness; and (c) an evidence-graded catalogue of candidate solutions explicitly mapped to the issues identified for ENS DAO in Phase 1. This package will be submitted to the designated ENS stakeholder group for review.

Within one week of submission, the research team and ENS stakeholders will convene a milestone check-in call to: (1) test the relevance and perceived transferability of comparative reforms to ENS DAO; (2) confirm that the proposed focus areas and analytic lenses for the retrospective are aligned with ENS objectives; and (3) agree on any refinements to the research emphasis or interpretive frameworks for Phase 3. The research team will then integrate ENS feedback into a revised Phase 2 synthesis and update the planned use of comparative evidence in the subsequent retrospective and final recommendation phases before formally closing the Phase 2 milestone.

Phase 4: Synthesis, Recommendations, and Community Validation

Goal

Integrate findings from Phases 1–3 into a coherent diagnosis of ENS DAO's governance and operational challenges and develop a prioritized, evidence-based set of recommendations and a governance roadmap that are validated with ENS stakeholders.

Activites

1. Synthesis of findings across phases
    - Map stakeholder-identified challenges and desired outcomes from Phase 1 against the retrospective findings from Phase 3 and the comparative evidence assembled in Phase 2.
    - Identify areas where multiple lines of evidence converge on the same problems and candidate solutions, as well as areas of persistent uncertainty, disagreement, or trade-offs that require explicit governance choices.
2. Recommendation development and structuring
    - Draft recommendations, each with a concise problem statement, proposed change, evidence base, risks, and implementation considerations.
    - Organize recommendations into clear categories, such as:
        - Governance infrastructure and process reforms (e.g., delegation mechanisms, proposal workflow, voting procedures, quorum/thresholds)
        - Organizational structure and accountability (e.g., working-group mandates, steward terms and elections, standing committees)
        - Communication and information architecture (e.g., forum practices, information flows, transparency standards)
        - Cultural and incentive alignment (e.g., contributor recognition, incentive design, participation norms)
3. Roadmap and success criteria
    - Sequence recommendations into a pragmatic roadmap with near-term, medium-term, and longer-term actions, including dependencies and prerequisites.
    - Propose high-level success criteria and monitoring indicators for key reforms, so ENS DAO can assess whether implemented changes are delivering the intended improvements.
4. Stakeholder review and validation
    - Share a draft synthesis and recommendations package with ENS stakeholders (e.g., MetaGov team, stewards, key delegates) for review.
    - Facilitate at least one discussion session to test the clarity, feasibility, and perceived legitimacy of recommendations, and to incorporate stakeholder feedback before finalization.

Output

1. Full research report
    - Executive summary and key findings.
    - Stakeholder analysis and governance challenge inventory.
    - Qualitative and quantitative evidence synthesis and stakeholder perspectives.
    - Comparative case analysis and evidence-graded assessment of candidate reforms.
    - Prioritized recommendations with implementation guidance, risks, and success criteria.
2. Governance roadmap
    - A concise, action-oriented roadmap that links specific problems to proposed reforms, indicates suggested sequencing, and highlights critical dependencies and enablers.
3. Community-facing materials
    - One or more forum posts summarizing major findings and recommended next steps for ENS DAO.
    - A slide deck for use in community calls and steward discussions.
    - A one-page summary highlighting top recommendations, rationale, and immediate next actions for decision-makers and contributors.

Data Management

All data generated through this study will be managed in line with professional evaluation standards for confidentiality, informed consent, and responsible data use, including the American Economic Association (AEA) guidelines for human-subjects research and qualitative interview data. A dedicated, access-restricted Google Drive workspace will serve as the central repository for all materials, including key informant interview (KII) transcripts and notes, community discussion summaries, forum exports, governance documents, and quantitative datasets. Access to this repository will be limited to the core research team, with role-based permissions and an auditable folder structure separating raw data, de-identified analytic files, and final outputs.

Personally identifiable information (PII) for interviewees and community participants will be collected only to the extent necessary for scheduling and context, stored in a separate contact file, and not linked to analytic datasets. Prior to transcription and coding, interview audio will be labeled with unique participant IDs, and any directly identifying details in transcripts (names, wallet addresses, email handles, specific employment affiliations where sensitive) will be removed or masked. Consent procedures will include: provision of a plain-language information sheet, explicit explanation of voluntary participation and the right to withdraw, and options for on-the-record, attributed comments versus anonymized or off-the-record contributions; these preferences will be recorded and respected throughout analysis and reporting. For community calls and asynchronous inputs, participants will be informed of how notes will be used, how

anonymity will be preserved, and how any quotations may be paraphrased or aggregated to avoid re-identification.

Documentary and quantitative data (e.g., governance proposals, voting records, treasury transactions, participation metrics) will be organized using a standardized naming convention, metadata fields (source, time period, governance domain, data type), and version control so that all relevant records can be reliably located, updated, and traced. The repository will be structured to allow downstream ingestion into the Metagov Open Grants data stack, including clear separation of raw versus cleaned data, machine-readable formats (CSV/JSON where applicable), and data dictionaries describing variables, coding schemes, and known limitations. At the conclusion of the project, the team will prepare a de-identified, analysis-ready subset of materials suitable for long-term use in Open Grants and future research, consistent with the consent conditions under which the original data were collected.

Data Analysis

Data analysis will follow a mixed-methods strategy aligned with the four project phases, integrating qualitative and quantitative evidence to build a coherent, triangulated understanding of ENS DAO governance. In Phase 1 (Stakeholder analysis and pre-retro data collection), interview and community-discussion data will be analyzed using structured thematic coding, combining a deductive codebook derived from the research questions with inductive codes that capture emergent issues. Multiple researchers will review a subset of transcripts to calibrate coding, resolve discrepancies, and refine the codebook, and will then produce stakeholder-group summaries and cross-cutting matrices (e.g., perceived challenges by role, perceptions of decision speed, communication clarity, and accountability). In parallel, pre-retro documentary and quantitative data will be catalogued and lightly profiled (completeness checks, basic descriptive statistics) to inform the design of the retrospective and identify priority gaps.

In Phase 2 (Comparative DAO research), the team will conduct structured case analysis of 4–6 comparator DAOs using a common template that captures problem statements, reform mechanisms, decision pathways, and outcome evidence. Qualitative materials (forum archives, blog posts, governance reports) will be coded against a standardized set of governance challenges and reform types, while available quantitative indicators (participation rates, proposal throughput, delegate concentration) will be extracted where feasible. Findings will be synthesized into an evidence-graded catalogue of reform options, with judgments about strength of evidence and context-specific preconditions documented explicitly.

In Phase 3 (Retrospective assessment), the team will link spending streams, initiatives, and governance processes identified in the data inventory to their intended purposes, reconstructing simple theories of change where possible. Using the assembled datasets, the analysis will combine descriptive statistics (e.g., funding flows over time, participation trends, execution timelines) with coded qualitative evidence (e.g., stakeholder narratives of successes and failures) to identify recurring patterns, bottlenecks, and leverage points. Interim findings will be reviewed with ENS stakeholders in a milestone session to validate interpretations and adjust analytic priorities before final synthesis.

In Phase 4 (Synthesis and recommendations), the team will integrate coded stakeholder data, comparative case evidence, and retrospective findings using matrix displays and evidence-to-recommendation tables that map each proposed reform to its underlying problem statement and supporting evidence. The resulting package will include a prioritized governance roadmap, with each recommendation linked to specific indicators and data sources that can be used to monitor implementation and impact over time, ensuring that the analytic logic remains transparent and auditable for the ENS community.